

PMK CHIEF S. RAMADOSS REFUSES TO ACCEPT POLL DEFEAT, BLAMES VOTING MACHINES

CHENNAI | BLAME THE BUTTON

After drawing a blank in the just-concluded Lok Sabha elections, Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) founder Dr S. Ramadoss, like his ally, AIADMK chief J. Jayalalithaa, comfortably shifted the blame to the Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) for his electoral defeat. The PMK had managed to win five seats in the 2004 general elections, but lost all seven seats it contested this time. Alleging that the machines were rigged, Ramadoss showed a dummy EVM and demonstrated how it could be manipulated. "The EVMs were re-programmed in a fashion that irrespective of the button you press, the vote will be cast in favour of rising sun (the symbol of DMK)," he said at the PMK's General Council meet. Sometimes it makes political sense to blame the machine rather than accept the mandate. *by Mahalingam Ponnusamy*



RAMADOSS DEMONSTRATES HOW EVMs ARE 'RIGGED'

H.K. RAJASEKHAR

OVER 300 TREES WERE UPROOTED ACROSS THE CITY AS GALE WINDS OF SPEED UP TO 110 KMPH SWEEPED THE BENGAL COAST.

KOLKATA | Fruit for Thought

Just a day after cyclone Aila hit the city, environment activist Subhas Dutta came up with an innovative plan to prevent uprooting of trees that blocked several roads and disrupted traffic. He sought permission from the army to plant fruit-bearing trees that "grow steadily, but are hard to dislodge unlike slender, faster-growing ones that are easily uprooted". He wants the plan to be "implemented soon". Heavier is better, quite literally.

by Abhijit Dasgupta



FALLEN TREES ON KOLKATA'S STREETS

LUCKNOW | Kin Ship

The Samajwadi Party is walking in the Congress's footsteps. Party chief Mulayam Singh Yadav has made his brother Shivpal Singh the Leader of the Legislature Party in Uttar Pradesh Assembly. Leaving the state in his brother's hands, Mulayam would rather consolidate his party and himself in Delhi. Shivpal, who heads the largest group of 97 MLAs in the Assembly, would be the leader of opposition and would enjoy the status of cabinet minister in the state. Now all Mulayam needs to do is find a replacement for Azam Khan.

by Subash Mishra

DELHI | Fighter Gurus

You've heard of the great Indian software outsourcing miracle, now get ready for the great combat flying boom. Nearly 30 Indian Air Force (IAF) top guns have been training the Malaysian Air Force to fly the Russian-built Sukhoi Su-30 since last year. The IAF happens to be one of the largest operators of the Su-30, now being built indigenously. The training has been good, judging by the fact that it has opened up opportunities in other sectors as well. Malaysia recently handed out a long-delayed contract to Rites, India. According to a senior defence official, up next is a proposal to train pilots of the Indonesian Air Force which also operates the Sukhois.

by Sandeep Unnithan



IAF PILOTS